

CORPORAL WOJTEK

The Soldier Who Was a Bear — a study of the most unusual enlistment of the Second World War

FILE No. 253 — DECLASSIFIED

SUBJECT: Wojtek — Syrian brown bear (*Ursus arctos syriacus*)

RANK: Private, later Corporal — service number 253

UNIT: 22nd Artillery Supply Company, Polish II Corps

SERVICE: 1942 – 1947 · Edinburgh Zoo 1947 – 1963

CONTENTS

In This File

01	An Army of Orphans — where the men came from
02	The Cub from Hamadan — April 1942
03	Growing Up in Uniform — the Middle East years
04	Private Wojtek, No. 253 — the loophole
05	Monte Cassino — three weeks under fire
06	The Rest of the Road — Ancona, the Gothic Line, Bologna
07	Winfield — a bear in Berwickshire
08	Sixteen Years in Edinburgh — the last exile
09	The People Who Knew Him
10	Fact and Legend — what the sources actually say
11	Legacy — monuments, books and a memory that would not die
A	Appendix I — Timeline
B	Appendix II — Facts and figures
C	Sources, further reading and photo credits

ABOUT THIS FILE

This study accompanies the Redacted Arsenal episode *The Soldier Who Was a Bear*. It goes considerably deeper than the film could. A ten-minute documentary has to choose. It keeps the strongest scenes and lets the rest go — the second-hand accounts, the contradictions between witnesses, the fates of the people who stood at the edge of the frame. This file is where the rest lives.

Wherever the sources disagree — and they disagree more often than the legend admits — we say so openly. Section ten is devoted entirely to separating what is documented from what grew in the telling. A story this good deserves to be told honestly; it survives the scrutiny.

All quotations from veterans are drawn from published interviews, memoirs and recorded testimony, and are credited where they appear. Photographs come from the collections of the Imperial War Museums, the Polona Digital Library, Polish state archives and other sources credited in full at the end of this document. Compiled and written for Redacted Arsenal, 2026. This document is distributed free of charge to viewers of the channel. It may be shared in unmodified form. It may not be sold.

SECTION 01

An Army of Orphans

To understand why grown men gave a bear a pay book, you must first understand who those men were — and what they had already lost.

The story of Wojtek does not begin in Iran. It begins in September 1939, when Poland was invaded from the west by Germany and, seventeen days later, from the east by the Soviet Union. In the Soviet-occupied half of the country, the machinery of repression started almost immediately. Between 1940 and 1941, in four great waves of deportation, hundreds of thousands of Polish citizens — soldiers, policemen, foresters, teachers, landowners, their wives and their children — were loaded into cattle wagons and sent east: to labour camps in Siberia, to collective farms in Kazakhstan, to the mines and forests of the Soviet interior. Many did not survive the first winter.

Then, in June 1941, Germany invaded the Soviet Union — and overnight, Stalin needed allies. Under the Sikorski–Majski agreement signed in London in July 1941, the Soviet government declared an “amnesty” for Polish citizens held on its territory. The word itself was an insult — an amnesty implies a crime — but it opened the camp gates. From every corner of the Soviet Union, starved and typhus-ridden people began making their way south, towards the recruiting stations of a new Polish army forming under General Władysław Anders, himself freshly released from the Lubyanka prison in Moscow.

What gathered around Anders was less an army than a migration. Alongside the men of military age came the civilians — women, children, orphans — because everyone understood that the army’s rations and the army’s route out were the only chance of survival. In 1942, in two great waves, Anders led his people out of the Soviet Union across the Caspian Sea to Pahlavi in Persia — modern-day Iran. By the end of the evacuation roughly 78,500 soldiers and 37,000 civilians had left Soviet territory; some accounts place the total higher, at around 115,000 souls. Behind them remained the graves of those who had not lived to see the ships.

The force they became — the Polish II Corps, fighting under British command as part of the Eighth Army — was therefore unlike any other Allied formation. Nearly every man in it had been a prisoner. Nearly every man had lost someone: to the camps, to hunger, to the NKVD execution pits of Katyn whose truth was then still officially denied. They were, in the words of one of their own veterans, an army of orphans.

Wojciech Narębski — who would serve alongside the bear in the 22nd Company and spend his later life telling the story — put it best:

“The fate of Wojtek was very similar to the fate of many Polish soldiers. Many of our soldiers also lost all their relatives; they were orphans. So our bear was an orphan among orphans. Maybe that is why we got along so well?”

PROF. WOJCIECH NARĘBSKI, VETERAN OF THE 22ND ARTILLERY SUPPLY COMPANY



Two moments, one bond: soldiers of the company with the tiny cub bought on the Hamadan road (top), and the fully grown Wojtek wrestling in camp (bottom). Between the two photographs lie three years and several thousand kilometres.

Keep that sentence in mind through everything that follows. It is the key to the whole story. The men who bought a starving cub on a Persian mountain road were not looking for a mascot. Without quite knowing it, they were looking for something to care for — proof that after everything the previous three years had done to them, they were still capable of gentleness.

SECTION 02

The Cub from Hamadan

A burlap sack, a Persian boy, and a price that reads like a fable: a tin of beef, a bar of chocolate, a handful of coins and a Swiss knife.

On 8 April 1942, a column of Polish soldiers and civilian refugees was moving along the mountain roads near Hamadan, in western Persia, on the long route from the Caspian port of Pahlavi towards Tehran. Somewhere on that road they met a local boy carrying a sack — and in the sack, a Syrian brown bear cub, a few weeks old, weak with hunger. Hunters had shot its mother; accounts differ on whether the boy was a shepherd's son who had found the orphaned animal or intended to raise it for sale, perhaps as a dancing bear.

What happened next is one of the best-documented small transactions of the Second World War. Among those who stopped was an eighteen-year-old civilian refugee named Irena Bokiewicz — Inka to everyone — who was instantly taken with the cub and pressed the soldiers to buy him. Lieutenant Anatol Tarnowiecki paid the boy. The price, as remembered by the participants: a tin of beef, a bar of chocolate, a handful of small coins, and a Swiss army knife.

Consider what that price meant. These were people who had walked out of labour camps owning nothing. Tinned meat and chocolate were not small change to them; they were wealth. An army that had almost nothing traded part of the little it had — for something to look after.

THE PURCHASE — 8 APRIL 1942

Where: near Hamadan, Persia (Iran), on the Pahlavi–Tehran evacuation route.

Price: a tin of beef, a bar of chocolate, a handful of coins, a Swiss army knife.

First keeper: Irena “Inka” Bokiewicz, aged 18.

Purchased by: Lt. Anatol Tarnowiecki.

Handed to the company: 22 August 1942.



The cub and his soldiers. Too young for solid food, Wojtek was fed condensed milk from an old vodka bottle through a nipple improvised from rags — the origin, veterans joked, of his lifelong affection for glass bottles.

For the first months the cub travelled with the civilian evacuation, cared for largely by Inka Bokiewicz. He was too young to chew, so the soldiers improvised: condensed milk, an empty vodka bottle, a teat twisted from rags. He slept in tents, was passed from lap to lap, and grew at the alarming rate bears grow.

On 22 August 1942 the arrangement was formalised in the way that mattered: the young bear was handed over to the soldiers of what was then the 2nd Transport Company — soon to be renumbered the 22nd Artillery Supply Company of the Polish II Corps. A corporal named Piotr Prendys was appointed his guardian, a role the men would come to describe, without irony, as that of a bear's mother.

They named him Wojtek — the affectionate short form of the old Slavic name Wojciech, which can be rendered, depending on taste, as “he who delights in war” or, more gently, “smiling warrior”. It was a joke, of course. It was also, as it turned out, a prophecy.

SECTION 03

Growing Up in Uniform

Iraq, Syria, Palestine, Egypt. A bear learns to wrestle, to ride in the cab of a truck, to drink beer like a veteran — and, once, to catch a spy.

From Persia the II Corps moved by stages across the Middle East — Iraq, then Syria, Palestine and finally Egypt — training, re-equipping and slowly turning a column of camp survivors back into a fighting force. Wojtek moved with the 22nd Company through all of it, and it was in these years that the bear the world remembers took shape.

He was, by every account, astonishingly gentle. His favourite game was wrestling: he would take on two, three, four soldiers at once, and he always won — but witnesses insist, again and again, that he kept his claws sheathed, and that a man he had pinned could expect nothing worse than a large wet tongue across the face. He learned to salute when greeted. He learned to march on his hind legs alongside the men. He learned — to the terror of passing drivers and the delight of everyone else — to ride sitting upright in the front seat of the company's trucks.



Wrestling in the desert. Veterans were unanimous on one point: Wojtek always won, and no one was ever hurt. Losing to him was considered an honour.

His appetites were those of the army that raised him. Beer became his reward and his passion — a bottle or two, tipped back standing on his hind legs, after which he would peer through the glass against the light to confirm, like any soldier, that it was truly empty. Cigarettes he did not smoke but ate — and only, by firm personal policy, if someone lit one for him first. A cold shower was his idea of paradise, and the company's bath hut had to be defended against him, because given the chance he would happily drain the entire water supply.



The reward ritual: beer, from the bottle, standing up. Photographs of Wojtek drinking circulated through the entire Eighth Army and made him famous far beyond his own company.

And it was the shower hut, of all places, that produced his one verified feat of counter-intelligence. The incident is placed by most accounts in Palestine, by some in Iraq. One night Wojtek, forever probing the defences of the bath house, pushed his way inside — and found a man hiding there. The man was not a Polish soldier. He was, the unit's accounts record, an Arab agent who had slipped into the camp to observe it, and who now found himself in a small dark room face to face with a very large brown bear. He surrendered on the spot, paralysed with fear, and was handed over without resistance. Wojtek's reward, in the version the company told ever afterwards: an extended, unlimited session under the showers.

“When I arrived in the company, the little bear had already been ‘serving’ there for a month. They called him Big Wojtek — and me, Little Wojtek.”

WOJCIECH NARĘBSKI, WHO JOINED THE 22ND COMPANY AS A TEENAGE SOLDIER

Through all of this ran the quiet, patient figure of Piotr Prendys — the corporal who slept in the same tent, fed him, disciplined him when he raided the provisions, and whom Wojtek followed like a shadow. The men called Prendys the bear's mother, and the description was accurate: the bond between them was that of parent and enormous child. By the time the company reached Egypt at the end of 1943, the cub bought for a tin of beef weighed some ninety kilograms, stood taller than a man on his hind legs when fully upright, and was — in every social sense that mattered — a soldier of the 22nd Company.

There was only one problem. Legally, he did not exist. And the company was about to board a ship to war.



A young Wojtek at sea with the convoy. The bear crossed the Middle East and the Mediterranean with his company — by truck, by rail and by ship.

SECTION 04

Private Wojtek, No. 253

British regulations were absolute: no pets, no mascots on troop transports. The Polish answer was a masterpiece of straight-faced bureaucracy.

In early 1944 the Polish II Corps received its orders: Italy. The Corps would join the Eighth Army on the peninsula, and the 22nd Company would sail from Alexandria aboard a ship every Pole knew by name — MS *Batory*, the elegant pre-war transatlantic liner of the Gdynia–America line, now in drab wartime service as a troop transport.

And here the company hit a wall. British transport regulations forbade animals — pets, mascots, anything on four legs — aboard troop ships. No exceptions were provided for. For most units this would have been the end of the story: the mascot stays behind, the men sail, the war moves on.

The Poles read the regulation more carefully. It forbade *animals*. It said nothing about soldiers.



MS Batory — the pre-war pride of the Polish merchant fleet, photographed 1937–1939. In February 1944 she carried the 22nd Company, and one officially enlisted bear, from Alexandria to Taranto. Image: Polona Digital Library.

So Wojtek was enlisted. Formally, in writing, into the roll of the 22nd Artillery Supply Company: rank — private; service number — 253. He was issued a pay book. He received an official ration allocation — a double one, the paperwork drily acknowledging his size — and, most magnificently of all, an official cigarette allowance, for a soldier who ate them. Some accounts add that the enlistment was blessed at the highest level, with General Anders himself said to have approved the arrangement.

When the company boarded at Alexandria on 13 February 1944, the documents were in order. The British inspectors checked them. A private of the Polish Army, name of Wojtek, walked up the gangplank with his unit — and the MS *Batory* sailed for Taranto with the only bear in recorded history to hold formal soldier's papers in any army.



Up the gangplank. The photograph long identified with Wojtek's embarkation: a bear boarding a troop ship, led on a chain, watched by an unbothered crowd.

It is worth pausing on what this actually was, because the legend tends to flatten it into a prank. It was not a prank. It was a deliberate, formally executed administrative manoeuvre, undertaken by a unit that had decided — collectively and seriously — that the bear was one of them and would not be left behind, and executed with such a straight face that the machinery of two armies accepted it. The men of the 22nd Company had spent years learning that paperwork could mean the difference between life and death. This time, they made the paperwork work for something they loved.

The absurdity of the result was best captured by a British witness some months later in Italy. Archibald Brown, a courier serving under General Montgomery, attended a roll call of Polish soldiers and noticed that exactly one man failed to answer his name — a certain Corporal Wojtek. Brown, puzzled, watched two men being sent to fetch the missing soldier, and wondered aloud what kind of man needed a two-soldier escort to a roll call.

“I was at the roll call of Polish soldiers, and only one failed to appear: Corporal Wojtek. ... I turned around and saw a quarter-tonne animal standing proudly on two legs. It was a truly magnificent sight... truly magnificent.”

ARCHIBALD BROWN, BRITISH COURIER TO GENERAL MONTGOMERY



Aboard ship, soldiers water the company's newest private in his travelling cage. On the crossing to Italy, Wojtek was a private with a pay book, not contraband.

SECTION 05

Monte Cassino

Three weeks, seventeen thousand tonnes of ammunition, and a bear on the supply line of the bloodiest battle of the Italian campaign.

The mountain needs little introduction. The abbey of Monte Cassino, crowning the heights above the Liri valley, anchored the German Gustav Line — the fortified belt that barred the Allied road to Rome. Between January and May 1944 three successive Allied offensives broke against it: American, British, Commonwealth, French and Indian divisions bled on its slopes, and the ancient Benedictine monastery itself was reduced to rubble by Allied bombing in February. In the spring of 1944, the task of taking the mountain passed to the Polish II Corps.



The ruins of Cassino town, May 1944 — a wrecked Sherman and Bailey bridge in the foreground, Monastery Ridge and Castle Hill beyond. Photo: War Office official photographer, Capt. Tanner — IWM TR 1799.

For the Poles the assignment carried a weight no other Allied contingent could feel. They were being asked to take the most infamous position in Italy — and they were doing it as an army whose country was already being quietly bargained away, whose families were in Soviet or German hands, and whose dead at Katyn were still officially a rumour. Anders accepted the task knowing exactly what it would cost and exactly what it would prove.

The company's war

Behind every gun on the mountain ran a supply line, and that line was the war of the 22nd Artillery Supply Company. For roughly three weeks around the decisive assaults of May 1944, the company's trucks ran ammunition, fuel and food forward to the artillery positions — almost exclusively at night, over mountain tracks registered by German guns, with headlights off. In that period the logisticians of the II Corps moved, among much else, some 17,300 tonnes of ammunition, 1,200 tonnes of fuel and 1,100 tonnes of food. The work had none of the glamour of the infantry's war and a great deal of its danger; a truck loaded with 25-pounder shells does not need to be hit cleanly to cease to exist.



Polish soldiers manhandle an ammunition box up the slopes at Monte Cassino. This was the 22nd Company's war: supply, at night, under fire, by hand where the trucks could not go.

Wojtek was there for all of it — initially, by the accounts of the men, unsettled by the noise of the guns, then acclimatising with unnerving speed, climbing trees to watch the flashes on the ridgeline. And at some point in those weeks, on the loading line where the trucks were fed, the bear did the thing that made him immortal: he watched the soldiers straining at the ammunition crates, stood up on his hind legs, stretched out his front paws — and asked, unmistakably, to be loaded.

They loaded him. From then on Wojtek worked the line alongside the men, carrying crates of shells — wooden boxes of roughly forty-five kilograms, most likely each holding four 25-pounder rounds — upright in his forepaws, from the lorries towards the gun positions. Every witness account agrees on one detail, and the company repeated it for the rest of their lives with the pride of a unit citation: **he never dropped a single one.**

Crates or shells?

Here the record splits, and this file will not pretend otherwise. The popular image — reproduced in a thousand illustrations and on the company's own badge — shows Wojtek cradling a single huge artillery shell. That image traces to a real account: John Clarke, a British soldier of the Black Watch, described a bear emerging upright from the tree line near his gun position, walking to within ten metres, and setting down what proved to be an artillery shell against the legs of the gun platform. The writer Wiesław Lasocki, whose post-war book did more than any other to spread Wojtek's fame, popularised the single-shell version.

Against it stands the flat, repeated testimony of Wojciech Narębski, who worked the loading line himself: single loose shells, he insisted, would have been far too dangerous to entrust to a bear, and what Wojtek carried were full sealed crates — faster to move, and safe to hug. "It is true," he allowed of the story, "but not single shells." Section ten weighs the two versions in detail. What no serious account disputes is the core: at Monte Cassino, a bear voluntarily carried ammunition on a supply line under fire, because the soldiers he loved were doing it and he was one of them.



18 May 1944, morning: the Polish flag over the ruins of the abbey. The mountain that had broken three offensives had fallen. The II Corps lost 923 killed, 2,931 wounded and 345 missing in the fighting.

On the morning of 18 May 1944 a patrol of the 12th Podolian Uhlans reached the summit and raised the Polish flag over the ruins of the monastery. The battle cost the II Corps 923 dead, 2,931 wounded and 345 missing — a price paid by an army that could not even write home about it, because home no longer answered.

In the aftermath, the company made its feelings about its bear official. The 22nd Artillery Supply Company adopted a new emblem: a bear, walking upright, carrying an artillery shell. It went onto the company's vehicles, its pennants, its uniforms — and eventually onto memorials on three sides of Europe. And the bear himself received the promotion by which history knows him. Sources differ, characteristically, on the timing — some place the corporal's stripes before the embarkation, by order of General Anders; others cast them as a reward for Monte Cassino itself. Either way, from 1944 onwards he was, to the entire Eighth Army, Corporal Wojtek.



Polish soldiers on the shattered slopes of Monte Cassino after the battle. Image: collection of the Institute of National Remembrance (IPN), Warsaw.

SECTION 06

The Rest of the Road

Monte Cassino made Wojtek famous. It was not the end of his war — the II Corps fought on up the Adriatic coast for another year.

The fall of Monte Cassino opened the road to Rome, but the II Corps did not march on the capital. Its war turned north-east, up the Adriatic coast, and the 22nd Company's trucks went with it. In the summer of 1944 the Corps fought the battle of Ancona — its only fully independent operation of the war, planned and executed under Polish command — taking the vital port city in July 1944 and shortening the Eighth Army's supply lines at a stroke. Through the autumn and winter came the grinding battles of the Gothic Line, the last great German defensive belt in Italy; and in April 1945, in the war's final weeks, the II Corps fought its last battle, taking Bologna on 21 April.

Through all of it, Wojtek did what he had done since Persia: he rode the trucks, worked the loading lines when work was wanted, wrestled anyone who volunteered, drank his beer ration, and served as the most effective morale instrument the Corps possessed. By 1945 he was a celebrity across the entire Mediterranean theatre — visited, photographed and fed by Allied soldiers, war correspondents, generals and at least the occasional statesman. A fully grown Syrian brown bear who saluted, marched, rode in truck cabs and held a service number was, veterans agreed, the one sight in Italy no one ever quite believed until they had seen it.

Victory in Europe came on 8 May 1945. For most Allied soldiers it meant one thing: home. For the men of the II Corps it meant the question they had been dreading. At Yalta, three months earlier, the Allied leaders had confirmed what the soldiers already suspected: Poland would lie within the Soviet sphere. The country they had fought for would be run by the system that had deported them. Going home, for many, would mean arrest, persecution, or worse; the officers understood this with total clarity. In 1946 the choice was made for most of them: the Corps was transferred not to Gdańsk, but to Britain, for demobilisation and resettlement.

On 26 September 1946 — most sources agree on the autumn of 1946, though a minority tradition places the company's arrival as early as 1944, a discrepancy examined in section ten — the men of the 22nd Company, and one bear, disembarked in Glasgow. Their war was over. Their exile was just beginning.



Camp life: Wojtek embraces a soldier of the company to the general delight of the audience. For men with no homes to write to, the bear was — in the veterans' own words — hope and family at once.

SECTION 07

Winfield

A demobilisation camp in the Scottish Borders, a bear at village dances — and the hardest decision the company ever made.

From Glasgow the 22nd Company was moved to Winfield Camp, on Sunwick Farm near the village of Hutton in Berwickshire — one of the constellation of camps across Scotland where the Polish Resettlement Corps processed an army that could not go home into civilians who had nowhere else to be. The Borders farmland could not have been less like the Liri valley, and the company settled into the strange half-life of demobilisation: language classes, resettlement paperwork, and the slow dispersal of men into British civilian life.

Wojtek, meanwhile, conquered Berwickshire.



Wojtek at Winfield Camp on Sunwick Farm, near Hutton in Berwickshire, after the war. Photo: Imperial War Museums collection.

He rode into the villages in the front seats of army trucks, to the lasting shock of oncoming traffic. He appeared — escorted, and by all accounts impeccably behaved — at village halls and local dances; the stories of the Borders in these years have him attending community events of every description, occasionally being asked to leave for no fault worse than the frank and unimprovable smell of bear. Local children adored him. The Polish soldiers, watching their strange celebrity charm the country they were being asked to make a life in, understood perfectly what he was doing for them: he was a bridge. It is no accident that the Scottish–Polish friendship organisations of the region would later claim him as an honorary member and symbol.

But Winfield was, by design, temporary. Through 1947 the camp wound down towards final demobilisation — and the company faced the question that had no good answer. A bear cannot be demobilised. He cannot be resettled into a Glasgow tenement or a Borders farm cottage. And there was a darker dimension, which the veterans discussed in deadly earnest: the new communist authorities in Warsaw would have been delighted to receive the famous soldier bear — a ready-made propaganda trophy, the beloved symbol of Anders' army paraded under a red flag. The men's response to that prospect was blunt. Some said openly that they would rather shoot him themselves.

It was Major Antoni Chełkowski, the company's commander, who arranged the compromise, and Piotr Prendys — the bear's mother — who had to carry it out. Wojtek would go to Edinburgh Zoo: safe, cared for, and close enough for the men to visit. And the Major attached one condition,

formally recorded and quietly extraordinary — the zoo was never to transfer Wojtek to anyone, anywhere, without his explicit personal consent. It was a legal lock on the cage door, aimed squarely at Warsaw. Whatever happened to the men of the II Corps, their bear would never be a trophy.

On 15 November 1947, Wojtek was formally demobilised and travelled to Edinburgh. The men who delivered him — Prendys among them — would remember it as one of the worst days of their lives.



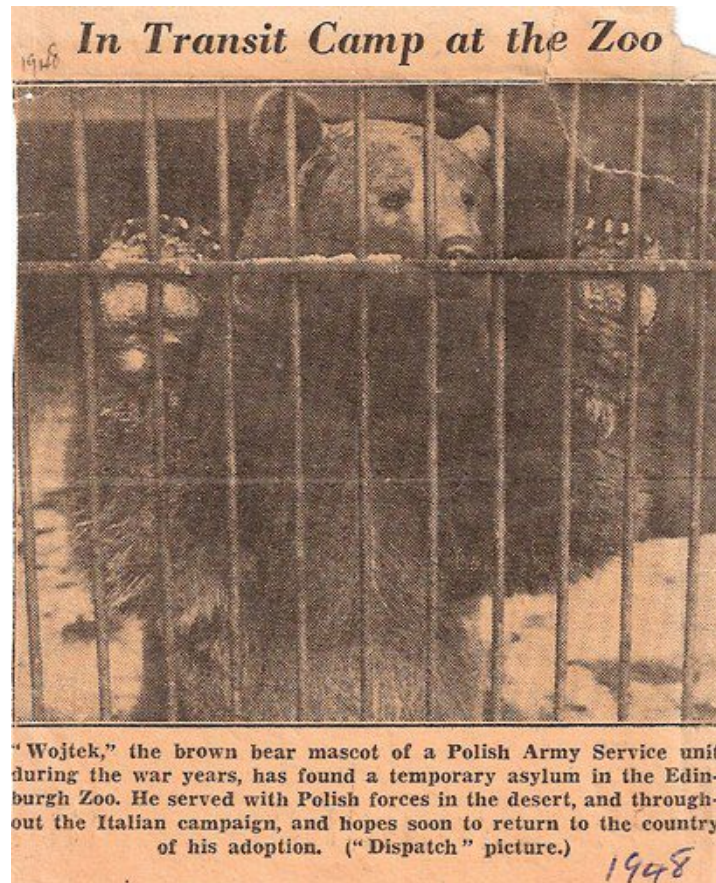
Wojtek in the line with Polish paratroopers in Scotland — standing his full height, entirely at ease. By 1946 he weighed well over 200 kilograms.

SECTION 08

Sixteen Years in Edinburgh

The soldier who had crossed three continents was placed, at first, in an enclosure of ten square metres. He lived behind bars for sixteen years — and his company never abandoned him.

The Edinburgh Zoo of 1947 was not the conservation institution of today, and Wojtek's first quarters were bleak: a cage of roughly ten square metres for an animal that had spent his whole life in the middle of a crowd. The keepers of the early years recorded what anyone could have predicted — the bear was visibly sad and lonely at first. He was a social animal in the most literal sense: he had never in his life been alone.



"In Transit Camp at the Zoo" — a 1948 press clipping. Note the final line: the paper still expected Wojtek to "return to the country of his adoption." He never did.

A newspaper clipping from 1948 — reproduced above — catches the moment with accidental poignancy. The caption describes the famous bear of the Polish Army Service unit as having found "a temporary asylum" at the zoo, and hoping "soon to return to the country of his adoption." The word doing the work in that sentence is *temporary*. Nothing about it would prove temporary: not the cage, not the exile, and not the political order that made return impossible — for the bear or for most of the men.

What the record shows instead is sixteen years of stubborn, rule-breaking devotion. The veterans came. They came from the Borders while the camps lasted, and from Polish communities across Britain afterwards. They ignored the barriers — the accounts are explicit and unrepentant — climbed fences, dropped into the enclosure, wrestled the old soldier one more time, tossed him lit cigarettes and, in the later, more supervised years, simply stood at the rail and talked to him. The keepers, understanding what they were watching, are said to have gone as far as donning Polish uniform jackets and learning scraps of Polish to comfort him.

Because that was the detail everyone noticed, year after year, and it is the one that still stops the heart: **he never forgot the language**. Whenever Polish was spoken near the enclosure, Wojtek would rise and come to the bars — alert, animated, waving in the old begging-for-a-treat gesture the company had taught him in the desert. Visitors who spoke to him in Polish got a response that visitors in English did not. An old soldier, listening for his company.



Old Wojtek at the bars, Edinburgh. Photographs of the ageing bear circulated in the Polish émigré press — and, occasionally, in publications in communist Poland, where his story survived censorship as a children's tale.

Fame of a gentler kind found him too. He became one of Edinburgh Zoo's great attractions, was featured on BBC children's television — including the programme *Blue Peter* — and settled into the role of the city's most storied resident. Guests threw him treats; the zoo tolerated, within reason, the Polish gentlemen of a certain age who kept appearing on the wrong side of the fence.

Wojtek died of natural causes on 2 December 1963, at the age of about twenty-two — a full span for a brown bear. The Polish community mourned him on both sides of the Iron Curtain; obituaries ran in the British press; and the men of the 22nd Company lost the last living piece of their unit. The company itself had ceased to exist in 1947. The bear had outlasted his army by sixteen years.



The old soldier in his Edinburgh enclosure, late 1950s–early 1960s.
Wojtek died on 2 December 1963, aged about 22.

SECTION 09

The People Who Knew Him

Wojtek's story is carried by a handful of names. They deserve more than a mention in passing.

Irena “Inka” Bokiewicz (b. 1924)

The eighteen-year-old civilian refugee who fell for the cub on the Hamadan road and talked the soldiers into buying him. She was his first keeper during the weeks with the civilian evacuation, before the bear was handed to the army. Like tens of thousands of the Anders evacuation's civilians, her subsequent road led through the refugee settlements of the Polish diaspora; she lived to see Wojtek become a legend.

Lt. Anatol Tarnowiecki

The officer who paid the boy on 8 April 1942 — the tin of beef, the chocolate, the coins and the knife — and thereby executed the single best-value procurement decision in the history of the Polish Armed Forces.

Piotr Prendys (Prendyś)

The quiet centre of the whole story. A corporal separated from his own family by the war, Prendys was appointed Wojtek's guardian in 1942 and became, in the company's universal phrase, his mother: he shared a tent with the bear, fed him, trained him, disciplined him and was loved by him

without reservation for five years and several thousand kilometres. It fell to Prendys to arrange Wojtek's transfer to Edinburgh Zoo in 1947 — by the accounts of those present, the hardest duty of his service. Like most of the company, he never returned to Poland, settling in Britain among the Polish émigré community. The Edinburgh memorial unveiled in 2015 — a soldier walking beside the bear — is widely read as the two of them: Wojtek and his mother, together in bronze.

Maj. Antoni Chełkowski

Commander of the 22nd Company. Chełkowski tolerated, then embraced, the bear's presence for the plainest command reason imaginable: morale. It was under his command that the enlistment manoeuvre was executed, and it was his personal condition — that Edinburgh Zoo could never transfer Wojtek without his explicit consent — that guaranteed the bear would never become a propaganda exhibit in communist Poland.

Prof. Wojciech Narębski, “Little Wojtek” (1925–2023)

Arrested in Vilnius by the Soviets at sixteen, released under the amnesty, and a teenage soldier of the 22nd Company through Monte Cassino, Ancona, the Gothic Line and Bologna — nicknamed Little Wojtek to distinguish him from the company's larger Wojtek. Narębski was one of the very few who did return to Poland, in 1947. He became one of the country's most distinguished geologists — a pioneer of geochemistry, a professor, a polar and volcanic researcher with a cape in the Antarctic named after him — and, in parallel, the tireless living witness of the 22nd Company: writing on the II Corps, correcting the legend where it drifted from fact, consulting on the books, films and statues, and unveiling the first Wojtek monument in Poland at Żagań in 2013. Promoted lieutenant-colonel in 2018, he died in Kraków on 27 January 2023, aged 97 — the last soldier of the 22nd Artillery Supply Company in Poland. Much of what this file can state with confidence, it can state because Narębski spent seventy years insisting on the difference between what happened and what made a better story.

Archibald Brown & John Clarke

The two British witnesses whose accounts anchor the legend from the outside: Brown, Montgomery's courier, with the roll-call story; Clarke of the Black Watch, with the single-shell sighting at Monte Cassino that became the badge, the statues and the myth — and the subject of the next section.

SECTION 10

Fact and Legend

Wojtek's story is so good that it has never needed embellishment — which has never stopped anyone. Here is what the sources actually support.

Verified beyond reasonable doubt

- **The purchase** — 8 April 1942, near Hamadan, for a tin of beef, chocolate, coins and a knife. Multiple consistent first-hand accounts.

- **The enlistment** — formal entry on the company roll with rank of private, service number 253, pay book and rations, to defeat the British transport ban ahead of the February 1944 embarkation on MS Batory. The central documented fact of the whole story.
- **Ammunition carrying at Monte Cassino** — attested independently by Polish participants and British observers. That it happened is not in dispute; the form it took is (see below).
- **Beer, eaten lit cigarettes, wrestling, truck cabs, the salute** — overwhelmingly attested, including photographically for the beer and the wrestling.
- **The shower-hut capture of an infiltrator** — a fixture of the company's own accounts, placed in Palestine or Iraq.
- **The Edinburgh years** — the fence-jumping veterans, the response to spoken Polish, the death on 2 December 1963. Attested by zoo staff, press and the veterans themselves.

CONTESTED: THE SHELL OR THE CRATE

The single most famous image — Wojtek cradling one great artillery shell — rests principally on John Clarke's eyewitness account and Lasocki's influential book. Against it stands Wojciech Narębski, who loaded alongside the bear and rejected the single-shell version flatly and repeatedly: loose shells would have been recklessly dangerous, and what Wojtek carried were sealed 45-kilogram crates, most likely of four 25-pounder rounds each. The versions are not irreconcilable — a bear who carried crates for three weeks may well have carried a loose shell once, and once is all an eyewitness needs — but a careful account must lead with the crates. It is worth noting the irony that the company's own badge chose the shell: the men themselves preferred the better image.

CONTESTED: WHEN THE CORPORAL'S STRIPES CAME

One tradition — supported by Brown's roll-call anecdote, which has a "Corporal Wojtek" in Italy — has the promotion arranged around the embarkation, some versions crediting General Anders personally. Another casts it as a reward for Monte Cassino. The sources cannot currently settle it; this file presents the promotion after Cassino narratively while flagging the earlier tradition, which is the honest maximum the evidence allows.

CONTESTED: THE ARRIVAL IN SCOTLAND

The dominant account, followed here, has the company reaching Scotland in the autumn of 1946 (26 September, Glasgow) with demobilisation and the zoo transfer on 15 November 1947. A minority tradition places an arrival as early as autumn 1944; it is difficult to reconcile with the company's documented fighting record in Italy through April 1945 and is best treated as a confusion with other Polish units already stationed in Scotland earlier in the war.

Legend, or beyond verification

- **"He helped load the guns themselves"** — an occasional embellishment with no support in participant accounts.

- **Precise weights and measures** — sources scatter between 200 and 250 kilograms for his adult weight and around 182–190 centimetres for his height; treat all such figures as ranges (Appendix II).
- **Direct quotations** — the veterans' quotes reproduced in this file come from published interviews and memoirs recorded decades after the events; they are testimony, with all the ordinary properties of sixty-year-old memory, and are presented as such.

SECTION 11

Legacy

The company dissolved in 1947. The country it fought for did not speak his name officially for forty years. The bear won anyway.

In communist Poland, the army Wojtek served in was an embarrassment to the official history — an army of the “wrong” exile, loyal to the “wrong” government, its Monte Cassino dead an awkward glory. The bear’s story survived those decades at the margins: in émigré publications, in family stories, and — disarmingly — as a children’s tale, a form too innocent to censor. After 1989 it came roaring back, and the twenty-first century has built Wojtek more monuments than most field marshals.



The Edinburgh memorial, West Princes Street Gardens: Wojtek and a Polish soldier — universally read as Piotr Prendys — walking together, on granite brought from Poland. Sculptor: Alan Beattie Herriot; unveiled 7 November 2015.

The centrepiece is in Edinburgh. The Wojtek Memorial Trust, a Scottish charity founded in 2009, raised some £300,000 to commission a bronze from sculptor Alan Beattie Herriot: a life-and-a-quarter-scale bear and soldier walking side by side, on a granite platform deliberately sourced from Poland — so that, in the Trust’s words, the two of them stand on a piece of the Polish homeland — with a four-metre relief panel narrating the journey from Persia to Scotland. It was unveiled in West Princes Street Gardens, beneath Edinburgh Castle, on 7 November 2015, on a suitably wet Edinburgh day, with Polish veterans in attendance. Author Aileen Orr — whose 2010 book *Wojtek the Bear: Polish War Hero* did much to revive the story in Scotland, and whose own grandfather, a

King's Own Scottish Borderers man, had known the Poles of Winfield — was among the driving forces; an annual Wojtek memorial day is now held at the site.



Szczecin's Wojtek, by Bogdan Walknowski (2019) — the bear with one paw on an ammunition box. One of a growing family of Wojtek monuments across Poland, Britain and Italy.

Poland answered in kind. The first Polish statue rose in Żagań in June 2013 — unveiled by Wojciech Narębski himself — and Żagań later gifted a replica to its Scottish twin town of Duns, a few miles from Winfield, unveiled in 2016. Kraków placed its Wojtek in Park Jordana; Szczecin, Sopot, Wrocław and Szymbark followed; plaques and memorials stand at Edinburgh Zoo, the Imperial War Museum in London, the Canadian War Museum in Ottawa, the Sikorski Institute in London — and at Cassino and Imola in Italy, where his company fought. The 22nd Company's badge — the bear with the shell — remains one of the most recognisable unit emblems of the Second World War.

The books and films kept pace: Lasocki's classic and Orr's revival, Łukasz Wierzbicki's children's bestseller *Dziadek i niedźwiadek* (with an introduction by Narębski), Maria Dłużewska's 2008 documentary *Piwko dla niedźwiedzia!*, the 2011 BBC co-production *The Bear That Went to War*, and an animated feature long in development. There is a Wojtek beer. There are Wojtek gingerbreads. There is, somewhere, a sand sculpture of him on a couch.

But the truest monument is the smallest: a line in a military ledger. *Wojtek. Private. No. 253*. Proof, in official ink, that in the darkest years of the twentieth century, an army of people who had lost everything looked at an orphaned animal and made the most human decision available to them. They made him family — and then they did the paperwork.

They lost their homes, their families and, in the end, their country. The one thing they refused to lose was him.

APPENDIX I

Timeline

Winter 1941/42	A Syrian brown bear cub is born in the mountains near Hamadan, Persia (Iran). His mother is killed by hunters.
8 Apr 1942	Polish soldiers and refugees on the Pahlavi–Tehran route buy the cub from a local boy for a tin of beef, chocolate, coins and a Swiss knife. Irena Bokiewicz becomes his first keeper.
22 Aug 1942	The bear is formally handed to the 2nd Transport Company — later the 22nd Artillery Supply Company. Piotr Prendys is appointed his guardian.
1942–43	With the company through Iraq, Syria, Palestine and Egypt. The wrestling, the beer, the cigarettes, the showers — and the capture of an infiltrator in the bath hut.
13 Feb 1944	Enlisted as Private Wojtek, service number 253, to defeat the British ban on animals aboard transports; embarks with the company on MS Batory at Alexandria, bound for Taranto.
May 1944	Battle of Monte Cassino. The 22nd Company runs the night supply line; Wojtek carries ammunition crates and never drops one. The abbey falls on 18 May; the Polish flag flies over the ruins.
1944	The company adopts its new emblem — a bear carrying an artillery shell. Wojtek is promoted corporal (timing contested).
Jul 1944	Battle of Ancona — the II Corps' independent operation on the Adriatic coast.
1944–45	The Gothic Line battles; the II Corps' war ends with the capture of Bologna, 21 April 1945.
26 Sep 1946	The company arrives in Scotland (Glasgow) and is stationed at Winfield Camp, Sunwick Farm, Berwickshire. Wojtek becomes a Borders celebrity.
15 Nov 1947	Demobilisation. Wojtek is transferred to Edinburgh Zoo — under Maj. Chełkowski's condition that he may never be transferred onward without the Major's consent.
1947–63	Sixteen years in Edinburgh. Veterans jump the fences to wrestle him; he answers to spoken Polish to the end. Television fame, including BBC's Blue Peter.
2 Dec 1963	Wojtek dies of natural causes, aged about 22.
2009–19	The Wojtek Memorial Trust (est. 2009) raises £300,000; the Herriot memorial is unveiled in Edinburgh, 7 Nov 2015. Statues rise at Żagań

	(2013, unveiled by Narębski), Duns (2016), Kraków, Szczecin (2019), Sopot, Wrocław and beyond; plaques at Cassino and Imola.
27 Jan 2023	Death of Lt.-Col. Prof. Wojciech Narębski, “Little Wojtek”, in Kraków, aged 97 — the last soldier of the 22nd Company in Poland.

APPENDIX II

Facts and Figures

THE BEAR	
Species	Syrian brown bear (<i>Ursus arctos syriacus</i>)
Service number	253 · Ranks held: private (1944), corporal (1944)
Weight	c. 90 kg at Monte Cassino; c. 200–250 kg fully grown (sources vary)
Height/length	over 182 cm — some accounts to c. 190 cm
Rations	official double allocation, plus a cigarette allowance (consumed, lit, orally)
Lifespan	winter 1941/42 – 2 December 1963 (c. 22 years)
THE UNIT	
Unit	22nd Artillery Supply Company (formerly 2nd Transport Company), Polish II Corps, under British Eighth Army
Emblem (from 1944)	a bear carrying an artillery shell
Monte Cassino supply effort	c. 17,300 t ammunition, 1,200 t fuel, 1,100 t food, moved largely at night under fire (c. 3 weeks)
Wojtek’s load	ammunition crates of c. 45 kg (c. 100 lb), most likely 4 × 25-pounder shells per crate
II Corps losses at Monte Cassino	923 killed, 2,931 wounded, 345 missing
THE EXILE	
Anders evacuation from the USSR (1942)	c. 78,500 soldiers and 37,000 civilians (some totals to c. 115,000)
Demobilisation camp	Winfield, Sunwick Farm, near Hutton, Berwickshire
Edinburgh Zoo	from 15 November 1947; first enclosure c. 10 m²
Edinburgh memorial	Princes Street Gardens, unveiled 7 Nov 2015; sculptor Alan Beattie Herriot; commissioned by the Wojtek

Memorial Trust (est. 2009, c. £300,000 raised); granite plinth sourced from Poland

APPENDIX III

Sources, Further Reading & Photo Credits

Principal sources and further reading

- W. A. Lasocki, *Wojtek spod Monte Cassino* — the classic first-generation account.
- Aileen Orr, *Wojtek the Bear: Polish War Hero* (Birlinn, 2010).
- Łukasz Wierzbicki, *Dziadek i niedźwiadek* — with an introduction by W. Narębski.
- Published interviews and testimony of Prof. Wojciech Narębski (incl. polishexiles.org, Project Kazimierz, Polish press 2013–2023).
- Imperial War Museums collections (photographs HU 16544–16548, MH 1246, TR 1799, NA 15141 and related).
- The Polish Institute and Sikorski Museum, London; Kresy Family (kresyfamily.com); British Library “Wojtek the soldier bear” (2015).
- polishhistory.pl, *Wojtek — A Bear Who Became a Soldier*; PAP; Wojtek Memorial Trust records; Canmore (Historic Environment Scotland).
- Maria Dłużewska (dir.), *Piwko dla niedźwiedzia!* (2008); *The Bear That Went to War* (BBC, 2011).

Photo credits

Cover & wrestling photographs: wartime photographs of soldiers of the 22nd Company with Wojtek, photographer unknown; via public collections including the Imperial War Museums and the Polish Institute and Sikorski Museum.

MS Batory: unknown author — Polona Digital Library (polona.pl), public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

Imperial War Museums photographs: HU 16544, HU 16546, HU 16547, HU 16548, MH 1246 (collections of the IWM, public domain); TR 1799 — War Office official photographer, Capt. Tanner (IWM, public domain); NA 15141 — the ruined monastery at Cassino, 19 May 1944 (IWM collection). Wojtek at Winfield Aerodrome, Sunwick Farm — IWM collection.

Polish flag over the ruins of Monte Cassino: unknown author, via Melchior Wańkowicz, *Bitwa o Monte Cassino* (Rome–Milan, 1945–47), public domain.

Polish soldiers on the slopes after the battle: collection of the Institute of National Remembrance (IPN), Warsaw; and Centralne Archiwum Wojskowe / Polish Institute and Sikorski Museum copies, public domain.

Soldiers with ammunition box at Monte Cassino: unknown author, via K. K. Koskodan, *No Greater Ally* (Osprey), public domain; NAC (audiovis.nac.gov.pl), photo Koch, public domain.

Edinburgh memorial photograph: the Wojtek Memorial by Alan Beattie Herriot, Princes Street Gardens.

Szczecin monument: photo Mike Pennington / geograph, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons; sculpture by Bogdan Walkowski, 2019.

1948 press clipping (“In Transit Camp at the Zoo”): contemporary newspaper cutting, Dispatch picture, 1948.

Additional wartime and zoo-era photographs: unknown authors, public domain, via Wikimedia Commons and archival collections as listed in the video description of the accompanying episode.

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Redacted Arsenal is a military history documentary channel about the unusual, the experimental and the cancelled — the files history almost forgot. This study accompanies the episode *The Soldier Who Was a Bear*, part of the Unlikely Recruits series.

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